

CSS with Google Fonts: Complete Guide

CSS Learning Resources

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Contents

1	Introduction	2
1.1	Why Google Fonts Matters	2
2	Getting Started with Google Fonts	2
2.1	Finding Fonts	2
2.2	Basic Integration: Link Method	2
3	Google Fonts URL Parameters	3
3.1	Common URL Parameters	3
3.2	URL Parameter Examples	3
4	Font-Display Strategy	4
4.1	Recommended Strategies	4
4.2	Display Strategy Examples	4
5	Real-World Examples	4
5.1	Example 1: Professional Blog	4
5.2	Example 2: Modern SaaS Application	5
5.3	Example 3: E-Commerce Store	5
5.4	Example 4: Creative Portfolio	6
5.5	Example 5: Multilingual Site	6
6	Performance Optimization	7
6.1	Load Only What You Need	7
6.2	Variable Fonts (Modern Optimization)	7
6.3	Preloading for Critical Fonts	7
6.4	Subset Strategy	8
6.5	Text Parameter (Extreme Optimization)	8
6.6	Performance Checklist	8
7	CSS Implementation Methods	8
7.1	Method 1: HTML Link (Recommended for Most Projects)	8
7.2	Method 2: @import in CSS	9
7.3	Method 3: Google Fonts API (Advanced)	9

8	Common Font Combinations	9
8.1	Classic Serif + Sans-Serif	9
8.2	Modern Minimalist	10
8.3	Bold + Readable	10
8.4	Elegant Professional	10
8.5	Tech-Forward	10
8.6	Warm Friendly	10
9	Browser Support and Fallbacks	10
9.1	Fallback Font Stack Strategy	10
9.2	System Font Fallback	11
9.3	Browser Compatibility	11
10	Common Mistakes	11
10.1	Mistake 1: Missing Display Parameter	11
10.2	Mistake 2: Loading Too Many Weights	11
10.3	Mistake 3: No Fallback Fonts	12
10.4	Mistake 4: Not Using font-weight in CSS	12
10.5	Mistake 5: Using @import in HTML	12
11	Advanced Techniques	12
11.1	Responsive Font Loading	12
11.2	Color Scheme Integration	13
11.3	Variable Font with Custom Axes	13
11.4	Language-Specific Subset Loading	14
11.5	Font Loading with JavaScript	14
12	Accessibility with Google Fonts	15
12.1	Readable Font Selection	15
12.2	Sufficient Color Contrast	15
12.3	Respect Motion Preferences	15
13	Troubleshooting	15
13.1	Fonts Not Loading	15
13.2	FOUT (Flash of Unstyled Text)	16
13.3	Slow Loading	16
14	Quick Reference	16
14.1	Minimal Setup	16
14.2	Production Setup	17
14.3	Performance Checklist	17
15	Summary	18

1 Introduction

Google Fonts is a free, open-source typography library offering over 1,400 professionally designed font families. Launched in 2010, it revolutionized web typography by providing high-quality, legally licensed fonts that anyone could use without cost. Today, Google Fonts powers millions of websites, making it one of the most accessible and popular font services available.

Unlike traditional `@font-face` implementations that require manual font file management, Google Fonts abstracts away complexity. The service handles font optimization, browser compatibility, performance caching, and CDN delivery automatically. For developers, this means minimal setup to unlock professional typography.

1.1 Why Google Fonts Matters

- **Free and Legal:** 1,400+ open-source fonts, no licensing concerns
- **Performance:** CDN-optimized delivery with aggressive caching
- **Variable Fonts:** Many fonts support weight/style variations in single file
- **Easy Integration:** Single line of HTML or CSS import
- **Automatic Optimization:** Google handles format selection and subsetting
- **Global Reach:** Served from Google's worldwide CDN network
- **Accessibility:** Many fonts optimized for readability and accessibility

2 Getting Started with Google Fonts

2.1 Finding Fonts

The Google Fonts website (fonts.google.com) provides:

- Search bar for discovering fonts by name or style
- Filters by category (Serif, Sans-Serif, Display, Monospace, Handwriting)
- Filters by properties (weight, width, slant, optical size)
- Preview tool with custom text input
- Popularity and trending sections
- Collections for curated font combinations

2.2 Basic Integration: Link Method

The simplest approach: add a single `<link>` tag to your HTML head:

```
1 <!DOCTYPE html>
2 <html>
3 <head>
4   <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Roboto&display=swap"
      rel="stylesheet">
```

```
5 </head>
6 <body>
7   <p>This text uses Roboto font from Google Fonts</p>
8 </body>
9 </html>
```

Then use in CSS:

```
1 body {
2   font-family: 'Roboto', sans-serif;
3 }
```

3 Google Fonts URL Parameters

The Google Fonts URL is highly customizable through query parameters. Understanding these enables precise control over what fonts load.

3.1 Common URL Parameters

Parameter	Description	Example
family	Font family name(s)	family=Roboto
wght	Font weights to load	wght@400;700
ital	Italic variants	ital@0;1
display	Font display property	display=swap
subset	Character subset	subset=latin-ext
text	Custom characters only	text=HelloWorld

3.2 URL Parameter Examples

Single font, regular weight:

```
1 <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Roboto&display=swap" rel="stylesheet">
```

Single font, multiple weights:

```
1 <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Roboto:wght@300;400;700&
  display=swap" rel="stylesheet">
```

Single font, weights and italics:

```
1 <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Roboto:ital,wght@0,400;0,700;1,400;1,700&
  display=swap" rel="stylesheet">
```

Multiple fonts:

```
1 <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Roboto+Serif:wght@400;700&family=Playfair+
  Display:ital,wght@0,700;1,700&display=swap" rel="stylesheet">
```

Variable font with range:

```
1 <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Inter:wght@100..900&
  display=swap" rel="stylesheet">
```

With Latin Extended subset:

```
1 <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Roboto&subset=latin-ext&
    display=swap" rel="stylesheet">
```

Specific characters only (extreme optimization):

```
1 <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Playfair+Display&text=
    HelloWorld&display=swap" rel="stylesheet">
```

4 Font-Display Strategy

Google Fonts supports all font-display values. Choosing the right strategy affects user experience and perceived performance.

4.1 Recommended Strategies

Strategy	When to Use	URL Parameter
swap	Headlines, important text	display=swap
fallback	Body text	display=fallback
optional	Decorative fonts	display=optional
block	Critical branding	display=block

4.2 Display Strategy Examples

Headlines (use swap):

```
1 <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Playfair+Display:wght@700
    &display=swap" rel="stylesheet">
```

Body text (use fallback):

```
1 <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Roboto:wght@400;500&
    display=fallback" rel="stylesheet">
```

Decorative fonts (use optional):

```
1 <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Fredoka+One&display=
    optional" rel="stylesheet">
```

5 Real-World Examples

5.1 Example 1: Professional Blog

Combining serif headlines with readable body font:

```
1 <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Playfair+Display:wght@700
    &family=Lora:wght@400;500&display=swap" rel="stylesheet">
```

```
1 h1, h2, h3 {
2   font-family: 'Playfair Display', serif;
3   font-weight: 700;
4   line-height: 1.2;
5 }
6
7 body {
8   font-family: 'Lora', serif;
9   font-weight: 400;
10  line-height: 1.6;
11  font-size: 18px;
12 }
13
14 strong {
15   font-weight: 500;
16 }
```

5.2 Example 2: Modern SaaS Application

Clean, minimalist sans-serif with multiple weights:

```
1 <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Inter:wght@400
2   ;500;600;700&display=swap" rel="stylesheet">
3
4
5 * {
6   font-family: 'Inter', -apple-system, BlinkMacSystemFont, sans-serif;
7 }
8
9 body {
10   font-weight: 400;
11   font-size: 16px;
12   line-height: 1.5;
13 }
14
15 .button-primary {
16   font-weight: 600;
17 }
18
19 h1 {
20   font-weight: 700;
21   font-size: 2rem;
22 }
23
24 .caption {
25   font-weight: 500;
26   font-size: 14px;
27 }
```

5.3 Example 3: E-Commerce Store

Bold headlines with complementary body text:

```
1 <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Montserrat:wght@600;700&family=Open+Sans:wght@400;500&display=swap" rel="stylesheet">

1 h1, h2, .product-name {
2   font-family: 'Montserrat', sans-serif;
3   font-weight: 700;
4 }
5
6 body, .product-description {
7   font-family: 'Open Sans', sans-serif;
8   font-weight: 400;
9   color: #333;
10 }
11
12 .price {
13   font-family: 'Montserrat', sans-serif;
14   font-weight: 600;
15   font-size: 1.25rem;
16 }
17
18 .button {
19   font-family: 'Montserrat', sans-serif;
20   font-weight: 600;
21 }
```

5.4 Example 4: Creative Portfolio

Distinctive display font for impact:

```
1 <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Space+Grotesk:wght@400;600;700&family=Space+Mono:wght@400&display=swap" rel="stylesheet">

1 h1 {
2   font-family: 'Space Grotesk', sans-serif;
3   font-weight: 700;
4   font-size: 3rem;
5 }
6
7 body {
8   font-family: 'Space Grotesk', sans-serif;
9   font-weight: 400;
10 }
11
12 code, pre {
13   font-family: 'Space Mono', monospace;
14   background: #f5f5f5;
15   padding: 0.5em;
16 }
```

5.5 Example 5: Multilingual Site

Loading fonts for multiple writing systems:

```
1 <!-- Latin, Greek, Cyrillic -->
2 <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Roboto:wght@400;700&
  subset=latin,greek,cyrillic&display=swap" rel="stylesheet">
3
4 <!-- Chinese, Japanese, Korean -->
5 <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Noto+Sans+JP:wght@400
  ;700&display=swap" rel="stylesheet">
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```

6 Performance Optimization

6.1 Load Only What You Need

Inefficient (loads all weights):

```
1 <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Roboto&display=swap" rel=
  "stylesheet">
```

Optimized (specific weights):

```
1 <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Roboto:wght@400;700&
  display=swap" rel="stylesheet">
```

6.2 Variable Fonts (Modern Optimization)

Variable fonts reduce requests and file size:

```
1 <!-- One file covers 100-900 weight range -->
2 <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Inter:wght@100..900&
  display=swap" rel="stylesheet">
```

```
1 h1 { font-weight: 900; }
2 h2 { font-weight: 700; }
3 h3 { font-weight: 600; }
4 p { font-weight: 400; }
5 .light { font-weight: 300; }
```

6.3 Preloading for Critical Fonts

Preload fonts used in above-the-fold content:

```
1 <link rel="preload" as="style" href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=
  Playfair+Display:wght@700&display=swap">
2 <link rel="stylesheet" href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Playfair
  +Display:wght@700&display=swap">
```


6.4 Subset Strategy

Load only needed character ranges:

```
1 <!-- Latin only -->
2 <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Roboto&subset=latin&
  display=swap" rel="stylesheet">
3
4 <!-- Latin + Extended (for European languages) -->
5 <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Roboto&subset=latin,latin
  -ext&display=swap" rel="stylesheet">
6
7 <!-- CJK fonts (Chinese, Japanese, Korean) -->
8 <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Noto+Sans+CJK+JP:wght@400
  ;700&display=swap" rel="stylesheet">
```

6.5 Text Parameter (Extreme Optimization)

Only load specific characters needed:

```
1 <!-- Load only "Hello World" characters -->
2 <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Playfair+Display&text=
  HelloWorld&display=swap" rel="stylesheet">
```

6.6 Performance Checklist

- Use specific weights, not all available
- Prefer variable fonts when available
- Use font-display=swap for non-critical fonts
- Preload fonts used in hero content
- Only load subsets needed for your audience
- Consider system fonts as fallback
- Monitor Core Web Vitals (Cumulative Layout Shift)
- Use @supports for advanced features
- Test on slow 4G networks
- Limit fonts to 2-3 families maximum

7 CSS Implementation Methods

7.1 Method 1: HTML Link (Recommended for Most Projects)

```
1 <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Roboto:wght@400;700&
  display=swap" rel="stylesheet">
```

Pros:

- Simple and straightforward
- Automatic browser caching
- Works without JavaScript
- Server can optimize headers

7.2 Method 2: @import in CSS

```
1 @import url('https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Roboto:wght@400;700&
  display=swap');
2
3 body {
4     font-family: 'Roboto', sans-serif;
5 }
```

Cons:

- Slightly slower (blocks CSS parsing)
- Renders one request after another
- Not ideal for performance

When to use:

- CSS-only frameworks
- Limited HTML access
- Component-based CSS modules

7.3 Method 3: Google Fonts API (Advanced)

For dynamic or programmatic font loading:

```
1 // Load fonts dynamically
2 const link = document.createElement('link');
3 link.href = 'https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Roboto:wght@400;700&
  display=swap';
4 link.rel = 'stylesheet';
5 document.head.appendChild(link);
```

8 Common Font Combinations

Google Fonts pairs fonts professionally. Here are proven combinations:

8.1 Classic Serif + Sans-Serif

```
1 <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Playfair+Display:wght@700
  &family=Lora:wght@400;500&display=swap" rel="stylesheet">
```

Playfair Display (headlines) + Lora (body)

8.2 Modern Minimalist

```
1 <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Inter:wght@400;600;700&
  display=swap" rel="stylesheet">
```

Inter (everything) - versatile single-font solution

8.3 Bold + Readable

```
1 <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Montserrat:wght@600;700&
  family=Open+Sans:wght@400;500&display=swap" rel="stylesheet">
```

Montserrat (headlines) + Open Sans (body)

8.4 Elegant Professional

```
1 <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Cormorant+Garamond:
  wght@400;600;700&family=Lato:wght@400;500&display=swap" rel="stylesheet">
```

Cormorant Garamond (headlines) + Lato (body)

8.5 Tech-Forward

```
1 <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Space+Grotesk:wght@400
  ;600;700&family=JetBrains+Mono:wght@400;600&display=swap" rel="stylesheet"
  >
```

Space Grotesk (interface) + JetBrains Mono (code)

8.6 Warm Friendly

```
1 <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Quicksand:wght@400
  ;600;700&family=Comfortaa:wght@400&display=swap" rel="stylesheet">
```

Quicksand (headlines) + Comfortaa (body)

9 Browser Support and Fallbacks

9.1 Fallback Font Stack Strategy

Always provide fallbacks:

```
1 body {
2     font-family: 'Roboto', -apple-system, BlinkMacSystemFont, 'Segoe UI',
      Arial, sans-serif;
3 }
4
5 .serif-text {
6     font-family: 'Playfair Display', 'Georgia', serif;
7 }
8
9 code {
```

```
10     font-family: 'JetBrains Mono', 'Courier New', monospace;
11 }
```

9.2 System Font Fallback

Graceful degradation if Google Fonts fails to load:

```
1  /* Uses system fonts if Google Fonts CDN is unavailable */
2  body {
3      font-family: 'Roboto',
4                  -apple-system,
5                  BlinkMacSystemFont,
6                  'Segoe UI',
7                  'Helvetica Neue',
8                  sans-serif;
9  }
```

9.3 Browser Compatibility

Google Fonts works in all modern browsers (99

Feature	Chrome	Firefox	Safari	Edge
Google Fonts (basic)	All	All	All	All
Variable fonts	62+	62+	11+	79+
font-display	60+	58+	11+	79+
unicode-range	All	All	All	All

10 Common Mistakes

10.1 Mistake 1: Missing Display Parameter

Wrong:

```
1 <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Roboto" rel="stylesheet">
```

Correct:

```
1 <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Roboto&display=swap" rel="stylesheet">
```

10.2 Mistake 2: Loading Too Many Weights

Inefficient:

```
1 <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Roboto:wght@100;200;300;400;500;600;700;800;900&display=swap" rel="stylesheet">
```

Optimized:

```
1 <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Roboto:wght@400;700&display=swap" rel="stylesheet">
```

10.3 Mistake 3: No Fallback Fonts

Wrong:

```
1 body {  
2     font-family: 'Roboto';  
3 }
```

Correct:

```
1 body {  
2     font-family: 'Roboto', -apple-system, sans-serif;  
3 }
```

10.4 Mistake 4: Not Using font-weight in CSS

Wrong:

```
1 <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Roboto&display=swap" rel=  
    "stylesheet">
```

```
1 strong {  
2     font-weight: 700; /* Only 400 weight loaded! */  
3 }
```

Correct:

```
1 <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Roboto:wght@400;700&  
    display=swap" rel="stylesheet">
```

```
1 strong {  
2     font-weight: 700; /* 700 weight available */  
3 }
```

10.5 Mistake 5: Using @import in HTML

Wrong:

```
1 <style>  
2     @import url('https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Roboto&display=swap  
    ');  
3 </style>
```

Better:

```
1 <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Roboto&display=swap" rel=  
    "stylesheet">
```

11 Advanced Techniques

11.1 Responsive Font Loading

Load different fonts for different screen sizes:

```
1 /* Mobile: lighter font weight */
2 body {
3     font-family: 'Roboto', sans-serif;
4     font-weight: 400;
5 }
6
7 /* Desktop: access to additional weights */
8 @media (min-width: 768px) {
9     body {
10         font-weight: 400;
11     }
12
13     h1 {
14         font-weight: 700;
15     }
16 }
```

Preload only necessary weights initially:

```
1 <!-- Load only 400 weight initially -->
2 <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Roboto:wght@400&display=
   swap" rel="stylesheet">
3
4 <!-- Load additional weights on demand -->
5 <link media="(min-width: 768px)" href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?
   family=Roboto:wght@300;700&display=swap" rel="stylesheet">
```

11.2 Color Scheme Integration

Fonts that adapt to dark/light modes:

```
1 @media (prefers-color-scheme: light) {
2     body {
3         font-family: 'Roboto', sans-serif;
4         color: #000;
5     }
6 }
7
8 @media (prefers-color-scheme: dark) {
9     body {
10        font-family: 'Roboto', sans-serif;
11        color: #e0e0e0;
12    }
13 }
```

11.3 Variable Font with Custom Axes

Advanced weight and width control:

```
1 <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Inter:wght@100..900&
   display=swap" rel="stylesheet">
```

```
1 .extra-light { font-weight: 100; }
2 .light { font-weight: 300; }
3 .regular { font-weight: 400; }
4 .semibold { font-weight: 600; }
5 .bold { font-weight: 700; }
6 .extra-bold { font-weight: 900; }
```

11.4 Language-Specific Subset Loading

Optimize for different languages:

```
1 /* Latin languages */
2 @font-face {
3     font-family: 'Roboto';
4     src: url(...);
5     unicode-range: U+0000-024F;
6 }
7
8 /* Extended Latin (European) */
9 @font-face {
10     font-family: 'Roboto';
11     src: url(...);
12     unicode-range: U+0100-017F;
13 }
14
15 /* Cyrillic (Russian, etc.) */
16 @font-face {
17     font-family: 'Roboto';
18     src: url(...);
19     unicode-range: U+0400-04FF;
20 }
```

11.5 Font Loading with JavaScript

Detect when fonts are ready:

```
1 if (document.fonts) {
2     document.fonts.ready.then(() => {
3         console.log('Google Fonts loaded successfully');
4         document.body.classList.add('fonts-loaded');
5     });
6 }
```

```
1 /* Fallback styling while fonts load */
2 body {
3     font-family: -apple-system, sans-serif;
4 }
5
6 /* Enhanced styling when custom fonts load */
7 body.fonts-loaded {
8     font-family: 'Roboto', sans-serif;
9 }
```

12 Accessibility with Google Fonts

12.1 Readable Font Selection

Choose fonts optimized for readability:

```
1 <!-- Dyslexia-friendly: use fonts with clear distinctions -->
2 <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=OpenDyslexic&display=swap"
  rel="stylesheet">
```

```
1 body {
2     font-family: 'OpenDyslexic', sans-serif;
3     line-height: 1.8;
4     letter-spacing: 0.05em;
5 }
```

12.2 Sufficient Color Contrast

Combine font choice with accessible colors:

```
1 body {
2     font-family: 'Roboto', sans-serif;
3     color: #000;
4     background: #fff;
5     font-size: 16px;
6 }
7
8 /* High contrast mode */
9 @media (prefers-contrast: more) {
10     body {
11         font-weight: 600;
12         color: #000;
13         background: #fff;
14     }
15 }
```

12.3 Respect Motion Preferences

Avoid animated font loading:

```
1 @media (prefers-reduced-motion: reduce) {
2     body {
3         font-family: -apple-system, sans-serif;
4     }
5 }
```

13 Troubleshooting

13.1 Fonts Not Loading

Check console for errors:


```
1 // Verify Google Fonts CDN is accessible
2 fetch('https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Roboto&display=swap')
3   .then(response => console.log('Status:', response.status))
4   .catch(error => console.error('Error:', error));
```

Ensure correct font names:

```
1 <!-- Space in font names: use + or %20 -->
2 <!-- Correct -->
3 <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Playfair+Display&display=
4   swap" rel="stylesheet">
5
6 <!-- Also correct -->
7 <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Playfair%20Display&
8   display=swap" rel="stylesheet">
```

13.2 FOUT (Flash of Unstyled Text)

Reduce visibility of font swap:

```
1 /* Minimize layout shift with sizing constraints */
2 body {
3   font-family: 'Roboto', Arial, sans-serif;
4   min-height: 1.5em;
5 }
6
7 h1 {
8   font-family: 'Playfair Display', Georgia, serif;
9   line-height: 1.2;
10 }
```

13.3 Slow Loading

Optimize URL:

```
1 <!-- Load only essential weights -->
2 <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Roboto:wght@400;700&
3   display=swap" rel="stylesheet">
4
5 <!-- Add preconnect to prioritize DNS lookup -->
6 <link rel="preconnect" href="https://fonts.googleapis.com">
7 <link rel="preconnect" href="https://fonts.gstatic.com" crossorigin>
8 <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Roboto:wght@400;700&
9   display=swap" rel="stylesheet">
```

14 Quick Reference

14.1 Minimal Setup

```
1 <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Roboto&display=swap" rel=
2   "stylesheet">
```

```
1 body {  
2     font-family: 'Roboto', sans-serif;  
3 }
```

14.2 Production Setup

```
1 <link rel="preconnect" href="https://fonts.googleapis.com">  
2 <link rel="preconnect" href="https://fonts.gstatic.com" crossorigin>  
3 <link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Roboto:wght@400;700&  
    family=Playfair+Display:wght@700&display=swap" rel="stylesheet">
```

```
1 h1, h2, h3 {  
2     font-family: 'Playfair Display', Georgia, serif;  
3     font-weight: 700;  
4 }  
5  
6 body {  
7     font-family: 'Roboto', -apple-system, sans-serif;  
8     font-weight: 400;  
9 }  
10  
11 strong {  
12     font-weight: 700;  
13 }
```

14.3 Performance Checklist

- Add display=swap parameter
- Load only needed weights (400, 700)
- Limit to 2-3 font families
- Use preconnect for optimization
- Provide fallback fonts
- Use variable fonts when available
- Test on slow networks
- Monitor Core Web Vitals
- Load fonts in <head>
- Combine multiple fonts in single request

15 Summary

Google Fonts democratized web typography, making professional font choices accessible to all developers. Key takeaways:

1. Use the simple HTML link method for most projects
2. Always include the `display=swap` parameter
3. Load only the weights and styles you actually use
4. Provide fallback fonts for graceful degradation
5. Use variable fonts to reduce file size and requests
6. Preconnect to Google Fonts CDN for performance
7. Combine multiple fonts in a single URL request
8. Monitor Core Web Vitals to measure impact
9. Test font loading on slow 4G networks
10. Choose readable, accessible fonts appropriate for your content

Google Fonts empowers developers to create beautiful, accessible websites with professional typography in just minutes. Master these techniques and elevate your web design to the next level.